

Persian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Iranian Persian

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Starter edition — five short lessons in two cumulative chapters.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/persian/lessons/

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Persian. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the letters and grammar needed for it, connects it to words you may already know, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. Read the Persian from right to left, but do not memorize an alphabet before you meet useful language.

This volume teaches contemporary Iranian Persian. Romanization remains beside the script in this starter edition and will fade gradually. Formal written and colloquial Iranian forms will be labelled when they diverge; Dari and Tajik are related future tracks, not silent substitutes.

Persian vocabulary has several historical layers. Some everyday words are inherited Iranian forms; many others came through Arabic and now follow Persian pronunciation and grammar. The point of etymology here is practical: it makes a word easier to remember without replacing its present meaning or use.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions are enough to establish the direction of the script, joining, one non-joining letter, omitted short vowels, and the contrast between borrowed and inherited vocabulary. Companion lessons: FA-C01-*.md.

1.1 سلام (*salâm*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Persian runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ا long *â*, م *m*. Most letters join inside a word. The tall ا is a non-joiner on its left side, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are required yet.

Where the expression came from

Salâm means “hello” and evokes peace. Persian borrowed it from Arabic, whose consonant family **s–l–m** carries ideas of peace, safety, and wholeness. Hebrew *shalom* belongs to the same older Semitic family. The word is borrowed history and completely ordinary modern Persian at once.

Use it now

Say سلام to one person or a group. It is a neutral, friendly greeting. Hear it, answer with the same word, and resist adding any grammar yet.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries the long *â*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salâm* once.

1.2 ممنون (*mamnun*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse final م from سلام, now at the right edge where reading begins. The visible sequence is م *m*, م *m*, ن *n*, و long *u*, ن *n*. Persian usually omits short vowels, so the first *a* is learned with the whole word. Here و carries the long *u*.

Where the expression came from

Persian received *mamnun* from Arabic. It describes someone as grateful or obliged and belongs to the Arabic **m–n–n** family associated with favor or kindness. In current Persian conversation, the whole word is simply a useful “thanks.”

Use it now

Build the smallest exchange: A says سلام; B answers سلام; A adds ممنون. Treat each expression as one social move.

One-minute checkpoint

Which visible letter carries long *u* in ممنون? Point to و, then say *salâm* — *mamnun* without looking.

1.3 بله (*bale*) — yes**Read only what this expression needs**

Read three letters: ب *b*, ل *l*, ه *h*. The short *a* and *e* are supplied by the reader rather than written as separate letters. The final ه remains visible even though careful speech ends with a light vowel-like sound rather than a forceful English *h*.

Use it now

Bale is a standard polite affirmative. A more casual answer exists, but one reliable “yes” is enough now: *bale*, *mamnun* — yes, thank you.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover *bale*. Read به; name the two short vowels that the writing leaves implicit; answer “yes” once.

1.4 نه (*na*) — no, and an inherited bridge**Read only what this expression needs**

You already know final ه from به and ن from ممنون. Put ن on the right and read نه: *n* plus an unwritten short *a*.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the two Arabic loans at the start of this chapter, Persian *na* continues an old Indo-Iranian negative family. Related forms occur across Iranian and Indo-Aryan languages. This is the first bridge from Persian toward Hindi and Urdu: not an instruction to learn those forms now, just a reason the tiny word may feel familiar later.

Use it now

Contrast only the answer: به *bale* — yes; نه *na* — no. Ask yourself a harmless yes/no question and answer it both ways.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the four-step chain: hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, ممنون, به, نه in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds a single sentence and a single grammar idea: Persian's linking vowel, *ezafe*. Companion lesson: FA-C02-esm-e-man.md.

2.1 اسم من ... است (*esm-e man ... ast*) — my name is ...

Read the Persian phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

اسم من سارا است
esm-e man Sârâ ast — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

The phrase reuses more than it appears to. In اسم *esm*, you already recognize ا, س, and م. In من *man*, both letters came from ممنون. The final word است *ast* begins with familiar ا and س; only ت *t* is new. Short vowels remain mostly implicit.

Use it now

Assemble four pieces:

1. اسم *esm* — name;
2. a spoken *-e* — the linker called **ezafe**;
3. من *man* — I/me, interpreted here as the owner;
4. your name, followed by است *ast* — is.

Only one reusable pattern is due: **noun + -e + owner**. Do not expand it into a table of possessive grammar yet.

Where the expression came from

The sentence displays two historical layers side by side. *Esm* is an Arabic loan related to Arabic *ism*. *Man* and *ast* belong to Persian's inherited Iranian core. Borrowed nouns and inherited grammar now work together as one Persian sentence.

One-minute checkpoint

What links *esm* to *man*? Say the normally unwritten *-e*. Then replace Sara with your own name and produce the full careful sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Everyday speech often shortens the final copula, and Persian has familiar and polite ways to ask another person's name. Those are later lessons. Keeping the full است visible here lets a new reader account for every part before conversational reductions begin.

Sources for this starter edition

Script descriptions follow the University of Texas at Austin Persian Online writing-system materials. The companion Markdown lessons are the canonical short-practice source for this edition.